

Wetlands Within Pine Savannas

PHOTO BY ALAN CRESSLER



SWAP Priority Habitat

Ecoregion(s)

Wet Pine Savannas

Southeastern Plains, Southern Coastal Plain

Herb and Shrub Bog

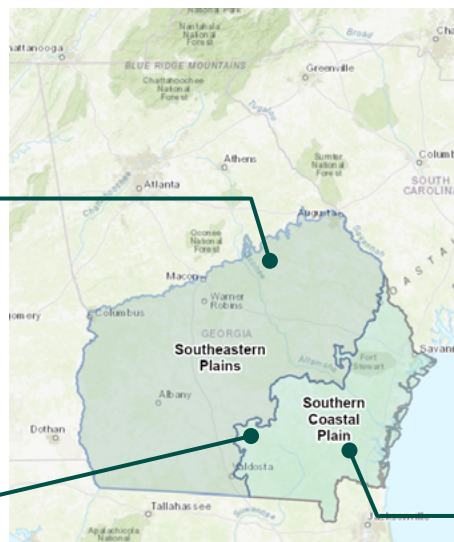
IMPORTANCE TO FORESTRY OPERATIONS

Wetlands within pine savannas were historically dominated by longleaf pine, but many have been cut, ditched, and drained to create tillable farmland or planted forests. These longleaf systems once fueled a thriving naval stores industry, producing turpentine, pitch, and resin. Today, they continue to support Georgia's #1 agricultural product—timber, and offer opportunities for sustainable harvest when managed carefully. Today, these wetland areas are recognized as ecologically critical zones within the broader pine savanna landscape. Forestry practices now emphasize BMP compliance, restoration-focused management, and prescribed fire to protect water flow, wildlife habitat, and biodiversity while maintaining limited timber value.

HABITAT DESCRIPTION

Pine Savannas with wetlands and bogs are areas with poorly drained soil and open canopies typically longleaf, slash, and/or pond pine. The ground cover is dominated with diverse grasses, sedges, orchids, composites, and carnivorous plants such as pitcher plants. Soils are acidic, nutrient-poor, saturated most of the year, and underlain by a subsurface clay hardpan.

Seepage slope herb bogs are open wetlands that develop on lower slopes or in swales within rolling, longleaf pine-dominated uplands. Seepage swamps and shrub bogs, also known as baygalls, bayheads, and pocosins, occur where water seeps from the base of a slope in depressions and ravines, at the head of blackwater streams, and, occasionally, along the edges of creek floodplains.



THREATS

- Habitat loss, degradation, and fragmentation, including clearing and conversion of habitat to agriculture, and residential and commercial development
- Fire suppression can degrade these habitats by allowing competition from undesirable competing vegetation.
- Alterations to hydrology such as ditching, draining, filling in wetlands, and water impoundments
- Invasion of exotic pest plants and animals
- Firebreaks, roads, and ruts caused by heavy vehicle traffic interrupt the natural progression of fire, change hydrology, and reduce movement of wildlife.
- Indiscriminate herbicide use or mechanical vegetation treatments can reduce plant biodiversity and negatively impact ecosystem function.
- Overstocked stands can degrade habitat by creating closed canopy conditions and reducing sunlight on the ground.

CONSERVATION MANAGEMENT RECOMMENDATIONS

- Avoid bedding, mechanical site preparation, and other soil disturbances.
- Retire fire breaks and allow fires to burn through these areas when possible.
- Avoid placing roads, drag lines, and firebreaks through these habitats.
- Protect from pollution and erosion runoff from nearby operations.
- Reduce invasion by woody vegetation utilizing prescribed fire on a 2-3-year rotation or with selective spot applications of herbicide if prescribed fire management is not an option.
- Maintain open canopy through selective thinning, if needed.
- Avoid offroad vehicle use. When roads or firebreaks are necessary use Georgia's BMP manual to construct water bars, broad based dips, stream crossings and other practices to reduce erosion and runoff.

MORE INFORMATION

Visit Georgia Biodiversity Portal for more information about specific species and habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIABIODIVERSITY.ORG](https://georgiabiodiversity.org)

Georgia's State Wildlife Action Plan has more information about specific management actions to protect these habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIAWILDLIFE.COM/WILDLIFEACTIONPLAN](https://georgiawildlife.com/wildlifeactionplan)

SELECTED PRIORITY SPECIES



See full list of Species
via QR code below

Georgia's Forestry BMP manual is designed to help landowners prevent or minimize impacts to water systems, the manual is available online.

[HTTPS://GATREES.ORG](https://gatrees.org)

View the GA SIC Storyboard
for more information and resources

